investing in skills. Education tracked financial behaviour: better-educated women were likelier to save and build long-term assets. The rest prioritised immediate family needs, also a function of those needs being more acute than the women being less enlightened.

A key caveat: only 6.62 per cent of Subhadra funds went into skill development. The report cautions that unless enterprise is backed by training, mentoring and market access, many of the fledgling businesses it spawned may struggle to survive. It proposes that the scheme be made smarter by weaving in digital literacy, skill development, zero-interest loans, financial counselling and stronger peer mentoring so that its effects evolve and spread over time.

THE BANKING EVIDENCE

The SBI Research study, based on the banking data of over 160,000 women, appears to validate the IIM Sambalpur findings. Comparing the transactions of 75,750 beneficiaries with 85,588 non-beneficiaries from like income groups, it found evidence of Subhadra setting off a virtuous cycle—often going well beyond the initial transfer.

Beneficiaries recorded an average increase of Rs 6,887 in month-end account balances, translating into a 45 per cent rise over comparable non-beneficiaries. The annual Rs 10,000 Subhadra cash transfer supplements their incomes, helping them maintain higher average bank balances. Consumption, too, increased by nearly 28 per cent. These gains remained visible for months before gradually tapering off as households utilised the funds. The benefits were spread across age groups but were most pronounced among women between 30 and 44, who logged the most savings and consumption. Interestingly, women with little or no formal schooling registered the sharpest increase in savings—nearly 73 per cent. Better educated women displayed a greater rise in consumption, reflecting income baselines. As women's savings increased, the bank balances of husbands, fathers and sons also improved—the latter's expenditure showed a marginal decline, suggesting women were assuminhg a greater share of household expenses, allowing other members to save more.

Like the IIM study, SBI concluded the scheme performs a dual role. For some, it's a bare social safety net. For others, it's working capital for micro-enterprises. If it continues to generate local demand and small businesses, it reckons the scheme could produce an economic impact of nearly Rs 1.5 lakh crore over five years. This study also suggests future expansion should prioritise better targeting—not just larger coverage. Cash transfers, it says, can become a mode to deliver sustainable livelihoods, not just be an end in themselves, if they link beneficiaries with self-help groups (SHG), skilling, markets and formal credit.



"What surprised policymakers was the ingenuity with which women deployed relatively modest sums they received"

PRAVATI PARIDA
Deputy CM and WCD Minister, Odisha

A STUDY IN EFFICIENCY

The recommendations are shaping Odisha's plans. Deputy chief minister and WCD minister Pravati Parida says the government chose to study how women used the first instalments before redesigning the scheme. What surprised policymakers, she says, was the ingenuity with which women deployed relatively modest sums. "Many invested in tailoring, fish farming, goat rearing et al. Those in SHGs pooled their grants together to start collective businesses," she says. Her field visits across Koraput, Malkangiri, Rayagada and Deogarh convinced her that anecdotal stories needed to be backed by evidence, leading to the commissioning of the studies.

The findings have prompted the state to integrate Subhadra with skill training, Mission Shakti, MSMEs, agriculture and credit schemes under the Subhadranku Mudra initiative. Says Parida: "We want every village, every panchayat to have women-led enterprises marketing products under the Subhadra Shakti brand." Mentorship from IIM Sambalpur, XIM University as well as Odia entrepreneurs is being planned, customised for age groups.

If a woman can build a business on her own with such small money, "imagine what she can achieve" with capacity-building, says Mrinalini Darswal, commissioner-cum-secretary, WCD. "We simply want to hold her hand until she becomes a successful entrepreneur."

"A role in decision-making doesn't come overnight," says Monisha Banerjee, director, social welfare. "It comes when women repeatedly demonstrate their capability." Empowering women without changing male attitudes can often create resistance rather than equality, so the government has begun engaging adolescent boys through its Advika platform and encouraging fathers to participate more actively in childcare. That Rs 833 in a month is clearly travelling a long way. ■